

INTERNAL LEARNING AID

Closure Reports

Evidence, benefits and handover at the end of delivery

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How to use this guide

Read a stage, then close the guide and try to say the core idea out loud. That small act of retrieval is worth more than reading the stage twice — it is the single most robust finding in the learning literature and the reason the interactive version withholds answers until you have committed to one.

Each stage ends with a set of contrasts: what good looks like, what usually happens, and **the tell** — an observable check you can run on your own team this week. Those are the parts worth arguing with. If a tell describes you, that is the useful outcome, not a failing.

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What closure is actually for

Accountability and learning, not administration

15 MINUTES

A closure report is the first piece of evidence about whether an investment was worth making. Writing it well means working against the moment: the people who know most are dispersing, and the document is due when time is shortest.

By the end you should be able to: Explain who reads a closure report, what decision it informs, and why most are written to be filed rather than read.

Why this document is hard to write well

Writing one of these well is harder than it looks, and the difficulty is structural rather than personal. Closure reports are produced at the point where the delivery team is dispersing, the funding has stopped, the sponsor has moved to the next thing, and nobody who will live with the result is in the room. The person holding the pen is usually the project manager, whose professional reputation is the subject of the document. No template solves that on its own, which is why the rest of this course is about the habits that do.

- Written last, by the people with the least time and the most exposure.
- Read — if at all — by people who were not there and cannot check the claims.
- Approved by a sponsor whose own record is being described.
- Filed somewhere that the next project team will not search.

Worked example. A closure report states 'the project delivered all agreed scope within the revised budget'. Every word is true. The budget was revised twice, upward, and the scope was reduced at the second revision. Nothing has been falsified and nothing useful has been said.

Who the audiences actually are

On the other end. A closure report has at least four distinct readers with incompatible needs, and a report

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that tries to serve all of them with one register serves none of them. The fix is structural: separate what happened from what it cost, from what it achieved, from what to do differently.

FOUR READERS, FOUR QUESTIONS		
Reader	What they need to decide	What they do with a vague report
Senior Responsible Officer	Whether benefits are on track and who now owns them	Signs it, because nothing in it is contestable
Finance / CFO	Whether costs are final and assets correctly recognised	Chases the numbers separately, ignores the narrative
The next project team	What to do differently, with specifics	Never finds it, repeats the failure
ANAO or internal audit	Whether claims made are supported by evidence	Tests the claim anyway, and finds the gap

The standard you are actually assessed against

For Australian Government digital and ICT-enabled projects there is a published standard for this document, and it is short enough to hold in your head. The Digital Transformation Agency's closure reporting standard sets seven criteria, and asks the agency to self-assess its draft against each one as Strong, Emerging or Nil before finalising it. Everything else in this course is depth behind one of those seven.

- Self-assessed by the agency, so the honest rating is the useful one — a report rated Strong on everything by its own author tells the reader nothing.
- Strong almost always means the same extra thing: not just what changed, but why, and what it cost.
- Several criteria require artefacts attached, not merely referenced — the original business case, the lessons learned register.
- Agencies may use their own template. The criteria apply either way.

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THE SEVEN CRITERIA

#	The report records...	Covered here in
1	Performance against the scope agreed in the business case, with the rationale and impact of any change	Stage 8
2	Performance against the agreed schedule, with the rationale and impact of any slippage	Stage 8
3	Outcomes achieved and benefits realised against the benefits management plan	Stage 3
4	Performance against the agreed budget, with the rationale and impact of any change	Stages 6 and 8
5	Completion of assurance activities under the Assurance Plan agreed with the DTA	Stage 11
6	Fit-for-purpose transition arrangements into business as usual	Stages 5 and 9
7	Lessons learned, and how they will be applied to other projects	Stage 4

Worked example. The pattern repeats across all seven. Emerging records what happened; Strong explains why it happened and what followed from it. A schedule table showing an eight-week slip is Emerging. The same table plus 'the identity broker token lifetime changed without notice, costing 11 weeks and \$3.8m of rework' is Strong.

Why someone independent checks your closure

Above certain values, a Commonwealth project's closure is independently reviewed. The Department of Finance runs a series of independent checkpoints across a project's life called the Gateway Review Process, numbered Gate 0 to Gate 6. The last of them, Gate 6, is the Benefits Realisation review: an independent check that the investment delivered what was promised, that benefits have named owners, and that the arrangements to keep harvesting them survive the project's disappearance. The gate exists precisely because self-reported closure was found not to be reliable.

- Gateway applies to non-corporate Commonwealth entities above the threshold: \$20m procurement or infrastructure, \$30m with an ICT component for programs.
- Gate 6 assesses delivery of the purpose and benefits of the investment, not delivery of the scope.

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- It looks for benefits that are identified, owned, and still being measured after the team has gone.
- The Senior Responsible Officer is the accountable party — not the project manager.

Worked example. A \$42m program with a \$14m ICT component is inside scope on two counts. Its Gate 6 review will ask who owns the benefit in eighteen months. If the answer is 'the project', there is no answer.

What good looks like

A closure report worth writing does three things: it states what was promised in the original terms, it separates what is now known from what is still assumed, and it names a person for every commitment that outlives the project. Everything else in this course is machinery for those three.

- Baseline stated as originally approved, with every revision shown as a revision.
- Claims marked as measured, estimated or asserted — and the difference visible.
- Every residual risk, benefit and obligation has a named owner who has agreed to it.

Closure is assembled, not written

The single change that most improves a closure report is starting it in month two. Almost everything it needs — the original baseline, the estimate against the actual, why an option was abandoned, what the vendor actually said — is easy to record at the time and expensive or impossible to reconstruct later. Treating closure as a document you sit down to write guarantees you will be writing it from memory, at the worst moment, about the things you remember rather than the things that mattered.

- Keep the original approved baseline somewhere it cannot be edited when the plan is revised.
- Record each estimate at the point it is made, so estimate-versus-actual exists without archaeology.
- Note surprises when they happen, in one line with a date. Shape them into lessons at closure.
- Capture the benefit measurement definition when the measure is designed, not when it is reported.
- Ask at each governance point who will own each benefit after go-live.

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Worked example. A team that keeps a single running file — baselines, estimates, surprises, ownership answers — writes its closure report in two days from evidence. A team that does not spends two weeks producing something weaker, and will not be able to answer the auditor eighteen months later.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
The report names the decision each reader will make with it, and answers that decision on page one.	The report follows the template section order and answers whatever the template asked.	Ask what decision changes if this report says something different. If nothing changes, it is a filing exercise.

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Evidence, baselines and what you may claim

The difference between measured, estimated and asserted

10 MINUTES

Every sentence in a closure report is one of three things: something you measured, something you estimated, or something you asserted. Reports that survive scrutiny mark which is which. Reports that do not, blur all three into the same confident past tense.

By the end you should be able to: Distinguish measured, estimated and asserted claims, and state a baseline that a later audit can test.

Measured, estimated, or just asserted

The confident past tense is the enemy. 'Processing time was reduced by 40 per cent' reads identically whether it came from a measured before-and-after, a modelled projection, or a workshop where someone said it felt about right. The reader cannot tell, so the reader either believes all of it or none of it — and an auditor will assume the weakest interpretation until shown otherwise.

MARKING THE CLAIM		
Kind	What backs it	How to write it
Measured	Data collected before and after, same definition both times	'Measured: median processing time fell from 14 to 9 days (Jan–Mar vs Jul–Sep 2026, n=4,102).'
Estimated	A model, with stated assumptions	'Estimated: 12,000 support contacts avoided annually, assuming the Q3 contact rate holds.'
Asserted	Informed judgement, no measurement	'Asserted: caseworker confidence improved. Basis: team lead observation, not measured.'

[Skip to learning content](#) the one people resist writing. It
er two: a report that openly

labels its soft claims earns trust for its hard ones.

Baselines, and reporting against the right one

A baseline is only useful if it is the one that was approved when the decision was made. Reporting against the most recent revision is the single most common way a closure report is technically accurate and substantively misleading. The fix is not to hide revisions but to show the chain: original, each revision with its date and reason, and current.

- State the original approved baseline first, always.
- Show each revision as a dated, reasoned change — not as the new normal.
- Report performance against both original and final, and let the reader see the gap.
- If no baseline was set, say so explicitly. It is a finding, not an embarrassment to be smoothed over.

Worked example. 'Delivered within budget' against a twice-revised budget is the sentence auditors look for. 'Delivered at \$51m against an original approved budget of \$38m, revised to \$47m (Nov 2025, scope addition) and \$52m (Apr 2026, integration rework)' is the sentence that survives.

Getting from the claim back to the data

A claim is traceable when a reader who was not there can get from the sentence to the underlying data without asking you. In practice this means a reference to a named source, a date range, and a definition — because the same metric measured two ways produces two answers, and the difference is usually larger than the improvement being claimed.

- Name the system or dataset, not the team that produced the figure.
- Give the date range and the sample size where relevant.
- State the definition when the metric could reasonably be defined more than one way.
- Where a definition changed mid-project, report both and say which is which.

Worked example. 'Processing time' can mean lodgement to decision, lodgement to notification, or first-touch to decision. A 40 per cent improvement in one may be a 5 per cent improvement in another. Unstated, the reader assumes whichever is most flattering, and is right to

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Choosing the comparison window honestly

Once a claim is marked and traceable, the remaining way to mislead honestly is the choice of window. Comparing a bad quarter with a good one produces a real improvement from real data and tells the reader nothing about the service. Nobody usually does this deliberately; the flattering window is simply the one that gets chosen, because it is the one that looks like success.

- State why the comparison periods were chosen, especially if they are not adjacent or not the same length.
- Use like-for-like periods where the work is seasonal — quarter against the same quarter, not against the quarter before.
- Give the sample size. A 40 per cent improvement on 60 cases is a different claim from the same figure on 6,000.
- Say what else changed in the window. A policy change, a staffing change or a campaign will move the same numbers.
- Where the trend is noisy, show it rather than reporting two endpoints from it.

Worked example. Processing time fell 41 per cent between Q2 and Q3. Q2 covered the annual re-registration peak; Q3 did not. Against Q3 of the previous year the improvement is 12 per cent. Both figures are real, only one is about the system, and the report that gives only the first is not lying.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
Every claim is marked measured, estimated or asserted, and the measured ones cite definition, period and source.	Every claim is written in the same confident past tense, and the reader cannot tell which are which.	Pick the strongest sentence in the report and ask where the number came from. If it takes more than one hop, it is not traceable.

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Benefits realisation

Why benefits are the business's job, not the project's

10 MINUTES

Almost no benefit is realised during a project. Benefits accrue afterwards, in the operational business, over months or years — which means the entity that promised them is not the entity that delivers them, and closure is the handover point where that responsibility either transfers or evaporates.

By the end you should be able to: Assign benefit ownership that survives closure, and schedule measurement that actually happens.

The money is spent before the benefit arrives

The project spends the money and the business earns the return, usually long after the project has ceased to exist. This is not a flaw in how projects are run; it is what a project is. The consequence is that benefits realisation cannot be a project activity — by the time it is measurable there is no project. What closure can do is transfer ownership cleanly enough that measurement still happens.

- Post-implementation review typically sits 6 to 12 months after closure, when effects have had time to appear.
- The Senior Responsible Officer remains accountable for benefits across the lifecycle, including after delivery ends.
- Realisation is the operational business's responsibility, supported by a named benefit owner per benefit.
- A benefit with no named owner is not a benefit; it is a hope recorded in a business case.

What a benefit owner has to have

Naming an owner is the easy part and is usually where it stops. An owner who cannot act is decoration. Four things have to be true, and closure is the last moment at which you can make them true while anyone is still paying attention.

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THE FOUR CONDITIONS

Condition	Test	Common failure
Named individual	A person and role, not a branch or committee	'The Service Delivery Group' — nobody
Has agreed	They have seen the number and accepted it	Told after the fact, disputes it later
Can influence it	Their decisions plausibly move the measure	Owner has no authority over the driver
Has the measurement	The data will exist without new work	Measure requires a collection nobody funded

Worked example. A benefit owner who agrees to a 20 per cent contact-reduction target, but whose branch does not control the channel strategy driving contact volumes, will report against it honestly and helplessly for two years.

Scheduling measurement that survives

Measurement lasts when it rides on something that already exists for another reason. What usually ends it is decay rather than disagreement: the measurement was scheduled into a forward plan that was superseded, in a system that was decommissioned, by a team that was restructured. Durable measurement is boring by design — it uses data already being collected for another reason, and it lands in a cycle that exists anyway.

- Prefer measures that ride on existing operational reporting over anything bespoke.
- Anchor the review date to an existing governance cycle, not to a standalone calendar entry.
- Write the measurement definition into the handover, so a successor can run it without archaeology.
- Record what would count as the benefit not being realised — and what happens then.

Worked example. 'Reviewed at the December Service Performance Committee, using the standing contact-volume report' for December 2027' by roughly

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Kinds of benefit, and double counting

Benefits come in distinct kinds, and naming which kind each one is keeps the savings a business case promises within reach of the entity. The distinction that matters most at closure is whether a benefit is cashable — whether a budget line actually falls — because a non-cashable efficiency gain is real, worth having, and will not appear in anyone's bottom line.

- Say which kind each benefit is. A closure report claiming savings that are non-cashable will be tested and found wanting.
- Non-cashable time savings need a stated destination — absorbed into existing workload is a legitimate answer, and it is not a saving.
- Check for double counting: two projects touching the same process frequently claim the same efficiency.
- Where a benefit was already counted in another business case, say so and halve it or drop it.

FOUR KINDS, AND WHAT EACH MEANS AT CLOSURE		
Kind	What it is	What closure must say
Cashable saving	A budget line falls	Which line, whose budget, from when
Non-cashable efficiency	Time freed, not money released	What the time is now used for, or that it is not
Cost avoidance	Spend that will not now occur	What would have been spent, and the evidence it would have
Effectiveness	Better outcomes at the same cost	The measure, and that no saving is claimed

Worked example. 'Caseworkers save 12 minutes per application' is worth having and is not \$2m. It becomes \$2m only if positions are removed or work is absorbed that would otherwise have needed new positions — and the report should say which, or say neither.

Check yourself

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WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
Each benefit has a named individual who has agreed, can influence the driver, and has a measurement that already exists.	Benefits are assigned to branches or groups, and measurement is scheduled into a plan nobody will hold.	Ask who will be asked about this benefit in eighteen months. If the answer is a team name, nobody will be asked.

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Stage 4

Lessons that change behaviour

Why lessons registers fail, and what works instead

10 MINUTES

Every entity has a lessons learned register and almost none of them change what the next project does. The failure is not that lessons are not captured — it is that they are captured as sentiments rather than as decisions, and stored where nobody looking for a decision would search.

By the end you should be able to: Write a lesson that is specific, transferable and addressed to a decision someone will actually face.

Making a register worth reading

Read any lessons register and the entries look like this: 'engage stakeholders earlier', 'ensure requirements are well defined', 'improve communication between teams'. These are not lessons. They are the categories under which lessons would sit, if any had been written. Nobody has ever read 'engage stakeholders earlier' and changed a decision, because it contains no information about which stakeholders, how early, or what happened when you did not.

- Written as sentiment, not as a decision that could have gone another way.
- Stored in a register organised by project, when the reader arrives with a problem.
- Generated in a workshop at the end, when memory has flattened into narrative.
- Never assigned to anyone with the standing to change the practice they describe.

Worked example. 'Engage stakeholders earlier' versus 'The state housing authorities needed 11 weeks to approve the data-sharing schedule, which we discovered in week 3 of a 16-week build. Any project touching state housing data should start that approval before design begins! Only one of those changes a plan.'

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The shape of a usable lesson

A lesson is usable when a reader facing a similar decision can act on it without contacting you. That requires four parts, and dropping any one of them returns it to sentiment.

FOUR PARTS		
Part	Question it answers	Example fragment
Context	When does this apply?	Projects requiring data-sharing agreements with state agencies
What happened	What was the specific event?	11-week approval cycle discovered in week 3 of a 16-week build
Cost	Why should I care?	6-week schedule slip, \$340k in held resources
Action	What should I do differently?	Initiate the schedule approval before design starts, not at integration

Why pooled numbers beat any single account

The most valuable thing a closure report contributes to an entity is its numbers, pooled with other projects' numbers. How long did the approval actually take, against the estimate? By what factor did the integration estimate miss? Enough of these and the next business case can be forecast from what comparable work actually cost, rather than from what this team hopes.

- Record estimate versus actual for the things that were estimated, not just the final totals.
- Capture the ratio, not only the absolute — a 3× miss on integration transfers; \$400k does not.
- Note the class the project belongs to, so a future reader can tell whether it is comparable.
- Publish into a pool the next team will search, not into a project folder they will not.

Worked example. The Commonwealth's published Gateway lessons material exists precisely to serve this function — aggregated observations across many reviews, which is the only level at which a pattern becomes visible.

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Write it down the day it surprises you

The four-part structure fixes how a lesson is written. It does not fix when, and the when is why registers are thin: a lesson recorded on the last day is recalled through the story the team has settled on. The alternative is unglamorous and works — capture at the moment of surprise, in a sentence, and shape it later.

- Capture when something surprises you, not when the project ends. A one-line note with a date is enough.
- Record the estimate as well as the actual, at the point the estimate is made — otherwise nobody remembers what was expected.
- Ask at each release retro: what would we tell a team starting this next month? That is the lesson, in the only form that matters.
- Keep it blameless in wording and specific in fact. 'The vendor was slow' is neither.
- Write the lesson properly at closure from the notes, rather than from memory.

Worked example. A one-line note in week three — 'assumed state data-sharing approval was 2 weeks, told today it is 11' — is worth more than an hour of workshop in week sixteen, because by week sixteen the team remembers only that approvals were slow.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
Lessons carry context, magnitude, cost and an action, and are published where someone with that problem would search.	Lessons are sentiments in a register organised by project, generated in a workshop on the final day.	Read a lesson and ask what you would do differently tomorrow. If nothing, it is a category label.

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Handover to business as usual

What has to be true before the team can leave

10 MINUTES

A handover is complete when the receiving team can run, support and change the thing without calling anyone who has left. That is the test worth setting, and it is a higher bar than a signed document.

By the end you should be able to: Specify an operational handover that does not depend on the delivery team remaining reachable.

Can they work without you?

A handover has worked when the receiving team can act on its own. There is one reliable sign that it has not landed yet: three months later, someone is still messaging a former team member who now works elsewhere. That informal channel is what makes an inadequate handover survivable, which is why it hides the problem instead of exposing it. The honest test is to ask what breaks if that person does not reply.

- Can the receiving team deploy a change without the delivery team present?
- Can they diagnose the three most likely failures from documentation alone?
- Do they know what the system costs to run, and who pays?
- Do they know which parts are understood to be fragile, and why?

Worked example. A useful exercise before closure: have the receiving team perform a routine change with the delivery team explicitly unavailable for a day. What they need to ask is the handover backlog.

What transfers, and to whom

Handover to different places, and the closure
repackaging. Bundling them into 'handed over to
operations' is how run costs end up unfunded and licences lapse.

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THE TRANSFERS

What	Typically to	Failure if unassigned
Operational support	Service desk / operations team	Users report faults to nobody
Change and enhancement	Product or platform owner	System freezes, then decays
Run cost and licences	A funded budget line	Renewal lapses, service stops
Residual risks	Named risk owner in the entity register	Risk disappears from view, not from existence
Benefits measurement	Named benefit owner	Never measured, quietly dropped
Data and records obligations	Records / information governance	Retention breach discovered at audit

Passing on what you know about the system

Every delivered system has parts the team understands better than anyone else ever will — the integration that depends on a retry loop, the batch job with a timing window, the configuration with history behind it. Delivery teams rarely write these down, because writing them down feels like confessing. Not writing them down means the receiving team discovers each one during an incident.

- List the parts you would not want to change without care, and say why.
- Name the failure modes you have already seen, and what fixed them.
- Record the workarounds in place and what they are compensating for.
- Say which dependencies are outside your control and who owns them.

Worked example. 'The nightly reconciliation assumes the provider feed arrives before 02:00. It has been late twice; both times the job was rerun manually by the platform team. There is no alerting on this.' That paragraph is worth more than most handover packs.

Who is receiving, and can they

Handover succeeds as a transfer of capability, and it is usually planned as a transfer of information. The receiving team may be smaller, differently skilled, already at capacity, or entirely unaware they are receiving it. It is possible in a document-completeness check, and an audit determines whether the service survives contact with its first incident.

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- Confirm the receiving team knows and has agreed — being named in a plan is not agreement.
- Check capacity, not just capability: a team already at full load will absorb this by dropping something else.
- Identify the skills the delivery team had that the receiving team does not, and say so plainly.
- Agree the support model in terms someone can act on: hours, response expectations, escalation path, who is called at 2am.
- Name the first three months' contact point on both sides, and put an end date on it so it does not become permanent informal dependency.

Worked example. A platform built by six engineers handed to an operations team of two, neither of whom has worked with the framework. That is a legitimate arrangement if it is stated and resourced, and a failure waiting to happen if the handover pack simply lands in their inbox.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
The receiving team has already made a change without the delivery team present, and the gaps that surfaced were closed.	A handover pack was delivered and a walkthrough held, and the delivery lead is still answering messages.	Ask the receiving team who they contacted last time something went wrong. If it is someone who has left, the handover has not happened.

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Financial and contractual closeout

Settling the money before the people go

10 MINUTES

The financial close is the one part of closure with a hard deadline and a statutory audience, so it repays doing while the team is still together. Every commitment either settles now or transfers to a named owner; anything left in between resurfaces later as an unexplained accrual, a lapsed warranty, or a payment nobody can approve.

By the end you should be able to: Close the financial and contractual position: costs finalised, assets recognised, obligations either discharged or transferred with an owner.

What must be true before the ledger closes

Financial closure is a set of positive assertions: every cost incurred is recorded in the right period, every commitment is either paid or accrued, everything capitalised is an asset that exists and works, and everything that will keep costing money has a budget holder who knows.

- All invoices received, matched and either paid or accrued in the correct period.
- Purchase orders and commitments closed, or carried with a documented reason.
- Capitalised costs tested against what was actually delivered — assets that exist and are in use.
- Work-in-progress cleared: nothing left sitting in a WIP account with no owner.
- Recurring costs transferred to a named, funded budget line for the next financial year.

Worked example. A program closes in May. In September, Finance queries a \$410k accrual nobody can explain. The delivery team is gone; the invoice related to a variation cancelled in March that was never backed out. Two hours of work in May became two er.

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Capitalise or expense

The distinction matters beyond accounting tidiness: capitalised costs sit on the balance sheet and depreciate, so an over-capitalised project reports a smaller hit now and an unexplained drag for years. The test is whether the spend produced an identifiable asset the entity controls and will derive benefit from — not whether the project would prefer it that way.

COMMON JUDGEMENTS AT CLOSURE		
Spend	Usual treatment	Where it goes wrong
Build of the delivered system	Capitalise	Includes work on abandoned options
Discovery and options analysis	Expense	Capitalised to protect the operating result
Data migration	Depends on whether it creates the asset	Treated inconsistently across releases
Training and change management	Expense	Bundled into the build cost
Post-go-live defect fixing	Usually expense	Capitalised as 'completion of build'
Licences prepaid beyond year end	Prepayment	Expensed in full, distorting the year

Worked example. Discovery explored four options and three were abandoned. The cost of the three is not part of the asset — an asset is the thing you have, not the thinking that led to it. Capitalising all four overstates the asset and understates what the decision cost.

Contract closeout

A contract runs on past the point where the work stops. Final acceptance is a formal act with consequences: it starts warranty periods, releases retentions, and closes the window in which defects are the supplier's problem rather than yours. Signing it because the project is over — rather than because the obligations were met — transfers risk quietly and

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- Confirm every deliverable was received and accepted against the contract, not against the current expectation.
- Record the warranty or defects-liability period, when it ends, and who will act on it.
- Settle retentions, milestone holdbacks and any liquidated damages position.
- Confirm intellectual property, source code and data have actually been delivered — not merely licensed in principle.
- Check transition-out obligations: what the supplier must still do, and for how long.
- Note obligations that survive termination — confidentiality, records access, audit rights.

Worked example. A twelve-month warranty is worth nothing if it expires unnoticed. Name the person who holds it, put the end date somewhere they will see it, and record what to do if a defect appears in month eleven.

Unspent funds and the incentive to spend them

Money left at the end of a project belongs somewhere specific: depending on the funding arrangement it lapses, returns to the entity, or must be formally rephased. The problem is that everyone involved knows an underspend can look like a poorly built business case, which creates real pressure to spend it on something defensible before the year closes. Naming that pressure is more useful than pretending it does not exist.

- Establish early what happens to an underspend under this funding arrangement — it is rarely the project's to keep.
- Report underspend as a variance with its cause, exactly like an overspend. Both indicate the estimate was wrong.
- Late scope added to consume a budget is a scope decision and must go through the same approval as any other.
- Where funds are rephased into a following year, record the approval and what they are now committed to.
- An underspend caused by descoping is a different fact from one caused by efficient delivery. Say which.

Worked example. 'Delivered \$3.1m under budget' reads as good news and may mean the scope was cut by a third. The honest line names both: what was not built, and what was genuinely cheaper than forecast.

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Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
Every commitment is settled or accrued, and every surviving obligation has an end date and a named holder.	Spending stopped, the PO was left open, and the warranty end date exists only in the contract PDF.	Ask who holds the warranty and when it ends. If nobody can answer in a minute, it will expire unnoticed.

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Decommissioning, data and records

What the law requires you to keep after you switch it off

10 MINUTES

Data held in a government business system is a Commonwealth record, and the obligation to keep it accessible outlives the system holding it.

Decommissioning is therefore a records decision before it is a technical one.

By the end you should be able to: Decommission a system without destroying Commonwealth records or losing access the entity is obliged to maintain.

Data in a business system is a record

Information created or received in the course of Australian Government business is a Commonwealth record under the Archives Act 1983, including the data sitting inside a business system. It cannot be destroyed because a project ended, a contract lapsed, or a cloud subscription was not renewed. Destruction requires authority — normally a records authority issued by the National Archives, which sets the minimum retention period.

- Records authorities give permission to destroy, retain or transfer, and set minimum retention.
- The obligation attaches to the information, not to the system that happens to hold it.
- Migration to a new system does not restart or discharge the obligation.
- Access must be maintained for the prescribed period, which can outlast several platforms.
- Disposal can mean secure destruction, transfer to the Archives, or transfer to another entity.

Worked example. A cloud workspace deleted when the subscription lapsed took eleven years of case data with it. Nobody decided to destroy those records; that is precisely the problem — destruction without authority is still destruction.

[Skip to learning content](#)

Keeping it readable, years from now

Accessibility is the obligation, and it asks more than storage does. If the only way to read the data is software the entity no longer licenses, running on an operating system it no longer supports, the obligation is not met in any practical sense — and the failure is discovered when someone asks for the data, usually under FOI or in litigation.

RETENTION APPROACHES AT DECOMMISSIONING		
Approach	Access in five years	When it is appropriate
Leave the system running	Good, at full run cost	Short residual period, active use continues
Migrate records to the successor	Good, if the migration is complete	A successor exists and the records fit
Export to an open, documented format	Good, with the schema retained	Most decommissioning of retired systems
Retain a database backup	Poor — needs the original software	Almost never sufficient on its own
Virtual machine snapshot	Fragile, degrades over time	Short-term bridge only
Transfer to National Archives	Good, permanent	Records of archival value, per the authority

Worked example. An export to CSV with the schema, the code tables and a plain-English data dictionary will be readable in a decade. A .bak file for a database version nobody licenses will not.

Sequencing the shutdown

Decommissioning in the right order protects both the evidence the closure report depends on and the records the entity is obliged to keep. The ordering is not complicated; it is simply never planned, because switching things off is treated as an operational task rather than part of closure.

- Sentence the records first: what must be kept, for how long, under which authority.
- [Skip to learning content](#) Start back and confirm it is complete
- Retain the closure evidence separately, with its queries and definitions.

- Confirm no downstream system, report or interface still consumes the data.
- Revoke access and integrations before deleting anything, so failures surface while recovery is still possible.
- Only then release infrastructure, close accounts and cancel subscriptions.

Worked example. Turn off the integrations a fortnight before deleting the data. Anything that breaks in that fortnight was a dependency nobody had documented, and you still have the system to turn back on.

What became of the system you replaced

Closure should also say what became of the thing being replaced. The common gap is the mirror image of the last section: the new service goes live, the report describes it, and the old system keeps running — costing money, holding duplicate data, and still accepting transactions. Closure should state the disposition of what was replaced, or say plainly that it remains in service and why.

- Name the system or process replaced, and its current status.
- If it is still running, say who owns it, what it costs, and when it will stop.
- If both are running, name the system of record — two sources of truth is a data-integrity issue, not a transitional inconvenience.
- Record any residual users who have not migrated, and what the plan for them is.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
Records were sentenced against an authority, exported with their schema and dictionary, and verified before anything was deleted.	The data was backed up, the subscription was cancelled, and the retention question was never asked.	Ask what happens if someone requests this data in five years. If the answer needs software you no longer license, you have storage, not access.

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Framing the report

Purpose, overview, objectives and the numbers

10 MINUTES

Most closure reports are written into a departmental template with fixed headings. Knowing how to think about evidence and benefits is necessary and not sufficient — you also have to know what belongs under 'Outstanding dependencies' and why 'Project overview' is the section people waste and then need.

By the end you should be able to: Write the framing sections: purpose, overview, objectives, business outcomes, key results, milestones and the financial summary.

The two sections everyone wastes

Document purpose and project overview are the two sections everyone treats as padding, and they are the reason the report is usable in three years. The reader in three years has no idea what the project was, what it was called internally, or which of four similar initiatives this one is. Two hundred words of orientation is the difference between a findable record and an archived file.

- Purpose names the decisions the report supports and who takes them.
- Overview states the problem the project addressed, in the words a stranger would use.
- Include the internal name, any codename, and the funding or investment reference — this is how it gets found.
- Give start and end dates, total cost, and the delivery model in two lines, not two pages.

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THE TWO SECTIONS PEOPLE WASTE

Section	What it is for	How it is usually failed
Document purpose	Says what this document decides and who must act on it	'This document reports on the closure of the project.'
Project overview	Orients a reader who was not there — problem, scope, dates, cost, who	A paragraph lifted from the business case, unchanged since 2023

Worked example. 'This report closes the Provider Status project and transfers six benefits, four residual risks and one unresolved dependency to named owners. It supports the SRO's decision to stand down programme governance, and Finance's treatment of \$47.3m of capitalised and expensed cost.' That is a purpose statement. It tells you who has to read it.

Objectives, business outcomes and key results

These three answer different questions, and keeping them apart is what makes the section worth reading. An objective is what the project set out to do. A business outcome is the change in the world that justified the spending. A key result is the measure that tells you whether the outcome happened. Closure reports against all three, and the interesting content is where they disagree.

- Quote the objective as originally written, not as it came to be described.
- An objective delivered while its outcome did not move is the most informative result in the report — say so.
- Key results carry a target and an actual. A key result with no target was a metric, not a key result.
- Where an objective was dropped or changed, record when and on whose decision.

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THREE DIFFERENT QUESTIONS

Term	The question	At closure, report
Objective	What did we set out to do?	Achieved, partially achieved, or not — against the original wording
Business outcome	What changed for the business or users?	The measured or estimated change, with its baseline
Key result	How do we know?	The metric, its target, and its actual

Worked example. Objective: 'Provide providers with self-service visibility of application status.' Achieved. Business outcome: 'Reduce avoidable support contact.' Measured at 18 per cent against a target of 40. Key result: contacts per application, target 0.6, actual 0.83. The objective was met and the outcome largely was not — which is the finding, and it is invisible if all three are reported as one sentence.

Milestones and the financial summary

Both sections are usually presented as a table of what happened, which is the least useful form. The value is in the variance: planned against actual, with the reason. A milestone table showing everything delivered on the revised date tells the reader nothing they could not have assumed.

- Milestones: planned date, actual date, variance, and the reason for any material slip.
- Show the original planned dates alongside any rebaselined ones, as with cost.
- Financial summary: original approved, revisions with dates and reasons, final actual, variance against the original.
- Split capital and operating, and state what was capitalised and on what basis.
- Name the recurring cost transferring to business as usual, and the budget line receiving it.

Worked example. A milestone table where every actual equals the planned date is a table that was written backwards from the outcome. Real delivery has variance; a report showing none has none.

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Outstanding risks, issues, dependencies and actions

This is the section that determines whether the report does anything, and it is routinely a copy of the RAID log with the closed items filtered out. A closure RAID section is not a status report — it is a transfer document. Every remaining item is either being accepted by someone named, or it is being abandoned, and abandonment is a decision that should be visible rather than implied by silence.

- Every item names an individual, a destination register, and a review date.
- An issue that will not be fixed is closed as accepted, with who accepted it — not carried indefinitely.
- Actions assigned to the project team are actions assigned to nobody. Reassign or close them.
- State explicitly if an item has no owner. That is a live problem, and burying it does not make it less true.

WHAT EACH COLUMN HAS TO CARRY		
Item	Must state	Failure
Risk	Owner, current rating, treatment, where it now lives	Transferred to a register nobody reviews
Issue	Owner, impact if unresolved, resolution path or acceptance	Reclassified as a risk to avoid resolving it
Dependency	The other party, what is owed, by when, who chases	Named as a system rather than a person
Action	Owner, due date, and what happens if it is not done	Assigned to the disbanding project team

Worked example. 'Risk: identity broker token lifetime may change without notice. Owner: Assistant Director, Platform Services. Rating: medium. Treatment: registered as a consuming system with Platform Identity, notification requested. Transferred to: Platform Services risk register, ref PS-R-118. Next review: December.' That item survives the project. 'Risk: integration dependencies — ongoing' does not.

Check yourself

[Skip to learning content](#)

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
Objective, business outcome and key result are reported separately, so a delivered objective with a flat outcome is visible.	One sentence covers all three, at whichever level of abstraction flatters the result.	Ask what changed for users, then ask what was built. If the same sentence answers both, the levels have been merged.

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Closing the open items

Quality, feedback, and everything that outlives the project

15 MINUTES

The back half of a closure report is where things either transfer or quietly evaporate. Every open item has exactly three legitimate destinations — closed, formally accepted, or carried to a named person with a date — and 'ongoing' is not one of them.

By the end you should be able to: Close out quality, team and stakeholder sections honestly, and leave no open item without a decision and a named owner.

Completion criteria, quality and the team

Three review dimensions that templates ask for and delivery people skip. Completion criteria are the conditions agreed at the start for calling the project done — reporting against them rather than against a general sense of doneness is what stops closure being a matter of opinion. Quality is not scope: a delivered feature that fails under load has been delivered and is not finished. And team performance is asked for in most templates and answered with a thank-you list, which wastes the only chance anyone gets to record what the delivery model actually cost.

- Quote the completion criteria as agreed, and mark each met, partially met or waived — with who waived it.
- Quality means defect rates, performance under load, accessibility conformance and security position, not test sign-off.
- Known defects accepted into production belong here, with severity and owner, not buried in the risk table.
- Team performance: resourcing model, vacancy and turnover, reliance on individuals, and what you would staff differently.

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WHAT EACH DIMENSION ASKS

Dimension	The question	The usual non-answer
Completion criteria	Were the agreed conditions for 'done' met?	'All deliverables were completed.'
Quality	Does it work under real conditions?	'The solution passed user acceptance testing.'
Team performance	What did the delivery model cost, and what worked?	A list of names and thanks

Worked example. 'Delivered with 14 known defects accepted into production, 2 of them severity 3, all with owners in the platform backlog. Peak load tested to 3× forecast; accessibility audited at WCAG 2.1 AA with two outstanding AAA items.' That is a quality statement. 'Passed UAT' is a note that a meeting happened.

Follow-on actions and recommendations

Three distinct things belong here, and separating them is what makes each one land. A lesson is for someone else, on a different project. A recommendation is for this entity, about how it works. A follow-on action is unfinished work from this project that someone must now pick up. The discipline worth borrowing is that at closure every open issue is either closed or becomes a follow-on action recommendation — there is no third state where it simply stops being mentioned.

- Every open issue at closure is closed, accepted, or converted to a follow-on action with an owner and a date.
- 'Ongoing' is not a state. It means nobody decided.
- Recommendations name who can act on them — a process owner, not the organisation in general.
- Say where each recommendation was directed and whether it was accepted. An unaccepted recommendation is still worth recording.

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THREE DIFFERENT THINGS

Type	Audience	Example
Lesson	Future projects, anywhere	Opt-in take-up should be forecast from opt-in precedents
Recommendation	This entity, about its process	Sentencing sign-off before any decommissioning date is set
Follow-on action	A named person, about this work	Rebuild the niche reporting function before the legacy register retires

Worked example. The most valuable line in a closure report is often a recommendation that changes a control: 'sentencing sign-off is a precondition of setting any decommissioning date'. One sentence, accepted, and every future decommissioning in the entity is safer. That is a different kind of output from a lesson, and filing it as one loses it.

Stakeholder feedback

Templates ask for it, and it usually appears as a paragraph asserting that stakeholders were satisfied. The useful version reports who was asked, what they said including the unflattering parts, and what it means for the thing now in operation. Treat it like any other claim: measured, estimated or asserted.

- Name the groups consulted and how — survey, interview, workshop — and how many responded.
- Report dissent, not just endorsement. Unanimous positive feedback usually means the wrong people were asked.
- Separate feedback about the product from feedback about the delivery, since they transfer to different owners.
- Mark it asserted where it is impressionistic, exactly as elsewhere in the report.

Worked example. 'Consulted: 4 provider organisations (interview), 61 internal caseworkers (survey, 38% response). Caseworkers rated the status screen positively; the strongest negative theme was that the notification wording still generates calls, which is a live issue transferred to Policy Branch as follow-on action A3.'

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Artefacts and the agreement to close

The artefacts section is an index, and its job is to make the project's outputs findable by someone who does not know they exist. The closure agreement is the act that ends the project, and signing it means the signatories accept that everything listed has in fact transferred — which is why it belongs last, after the sections that say what is being transferred.

- List each artefact with its location and its owner, not just its name.
- Include the things people forget: architecture decisions, data dictionaries, test evidence, contracts, the benefits plan.
- Say which artefacts are records with a retention obligation, and where they are held.
- The agreement names who signs, what they are attesting to, and the date.
- A signature is an acceptance of the transfers described. If a benefit has no owner, that is on the page above the signature, not hidden.

Worked example. 'Signed by the Senior Responsible Officer, confirming that the benefits, risks and obligations recorded in sections 6 to 9 have been accepted by the owners named there.' That sentence makes signing mean something. 'Signed to confirm project closure' means the project has stopped, which everybody already knew.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
Every outstanding risk, issue, dependency and action names an individual, a destination register and a review date.	The RAID log is pasted in with closed items filtered out, and the survivors are owned by branches.	Pick the third item in the list and ask who will be asked about it in March. If the answer is a team name, it has not transferred.

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Writing the report

Structure, candour and the shortfall paragraph

10 MINUTES

A closure report is read by people looking for one thing, in a hurry. Structure it so they find it, and say the difficult part plainly enough that the rest of the document becomes believable.

By the end you should be able to: Produce a closure report structured so a reader can find the decision-relevant content, including where targets were not met.

Structure for a reader in a hurry

Assume your reader arrives with one question and about ninety seconds. They will scan for their answer, and if it is not findable in that time they either ask you directly or decide for themselves what it probably was. Structure is therefore doing real work here: it is the difference between a document that gets used and one that gets filed.

- Lead with what was promised, what was delivered, and the gap. One page, no preamble.
- Put the benefits table where it can be found without reading the narrative.
- Give shortfalls their own heading. Buried bad news reads as concealed bad news.
- Put detail in appendices, but keep every claim's evidence reference in the body.

The shortfall paragraph

Every substantial project misses something. The instinct is to distribute those misses through the document so that none of them lands hard, which produces a report where nothing is wrong and nothing is trusted. The alternative is a single, direct passage that states what was not achieved, by how much, and why — early, in plain terms.

- State the shortfall in the same units as the original commitment.
- [Skip to learning content](#) blame, and distinguish forecast error from delivery failure.
- Say what was learned, and where that lesson has been recorded.

- Do not pair it with a compensating success in the same sentence. That reads as deflection.

Worked example. 'The forecast \$3.1m annual saving is currently measuring at \$1.2m. The system performs as designed; take-up is at 41 per cent against a forecast of 85 per cent. The forecasting method — which assumed take-up equivalent to the 2023 online lodgement rollout — is recorded in the lessons pool as an over-optimistic comparator for opt-in services.'

Language that survives scrutiny

Certain constructions signal to an experienced reader that a claim is weaker than it appears, and they will be tested first. Removing them is not about writing style; it is about not spending the reader's trust on sentences that cannot repay it.

CONSTRUCTIONS TO AVOID		
Written	Read as	Better
Successfully delivered	Delivered, with 'successfully' doing no work	Delivered [what], on [date], against [baseline]
Broadly in line with expectations	Missed, by an amount not stated	Missed by X per cent; expectation was Y
Stakeholders were engaged throughout	We held meetings	[Group] approved [decision] on [date]
Lessons have been captured	A workshop occurred	N lessons recorded in [pool], of which [example]
Within the revised budget	Over the original budget	Delivered at \$X against original \$Y, revised to \$Z

Assume only the first page is read

Assume one page is read. Not because readers are lazy — because a Deputy Secretary with forty minutes and eleven papers will read your first page and skim for anything that contradicts it. Everything else in the report exists to be checked by someone who has a specific question, which is a different kind of reader.

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- If you cannot summarise the whole report, then let the rest support it.

- Put the gap, the unresolved transfers and the money on that page. They are what a decision turns on.
- Length is not thoroughness. A 40-page report with the finding on page 27 has hidden it, whatever the intention.
- Detail belongs in appendices with the body carrying the reference — reachable, not in the way.
- If a section exists only because the template has the heading, say 'not applicable' and why, rather than filling it.

Worked example. The test: hand your first page to someone who has never heard of the project and ask what they would do next. If they cannot name a decision, the page is describing the project rather than closing it.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
The shortfall has its own heading, its own figures against the original commitment, and no compensating success beside it.	Misses are distributed through the narrative in hedged language, and the budget is reported against the revision.	Search the document for 'broadly', 'largely' and 'revised'. Each one marks a number somebody chose not to state.

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Assurance and audit readiness

Writing for a reader who will test the claim

10 MINUTES

A closure report's claims travel. They can reappear in annual performance statements, which are audited, and in ANAO performance audits years later. Write as though each claim will be tested, because it may be.

By the end you should be able to: Anticipate how a closure claim will be tested, and hold the evidence that makes it stand.

Where closure claims resurface

Performance information from delivery flows into the entity's corporate plan reporting and annual performance statements, which are subject to audit. A benefit claimed at closure can therefore be tested by someone with statutory powers, no relationship with the project, and a year's distance. That is a different reader from the sponsor who signed the report.

- Annual performance statements report against the entity's purposes and are audited.
- ANAO performance audits examine whether reported information is meaningful and supported.
- Gateway lessons material aggregates across entities, so patterns become visible beyond one project.
- The evidence has to survive the project's systems being decommissioned.

What a tester actually does

Audit reads for evidence. It selects a claim, asks what supports it, and follows the chain until it either reaches primary data or runs out. Most claims fail not because they were false but because the chain breaks — the analyst left, the extract was not retained, the definition was not written down.

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THE CHAIN

Step	What must exist	Where it usually breaks
The claim	A specific, quantified statement	Vague wording admits no test
The method	How the figure was derived, written down	Lived in an analyst's spreadsheet
The data	Retained extract or reproducible query	System decommissioned, extract not kept
The definition	What was counted, and what was not	Never recorded; two readings possible
The approval	Who accepted the figure and when	Approved verbally, no record

Deciding what to keep before it is deleted

Evidence has to outlive the systems that produced it, and that is a decision somebody makes at closure. Systems are decommissioned, licences lapse, cloud accounts are closed, and the extract that supported the headline benefit goes with them. Deciding what to retain is part of writing the report, not an afterthought for records management.

- Retain the extract, not the dashboard — dashboards depend on systems that will be turned off.
- Keep the query or method alongside the data, so the figure can be reproduced rather than merely cited.
- Record the definition in the same place, in plain words.
- Confirm the retention period against the entity's obligations, and name who holds it.

Worked example. A benefit claim supported by 'the Power BI dashboard' is supported by nothing eighteen months after the workspace is deleted. A retained CSV, the SQL that produced it, and a paragraph defining the metric will still answer the question.

Recording what assurance actually did

One of the seven criteria is about assurance itself: the report must record that the activities in the Assurance Plan agreed with the Digital Transformation Agency were completed, note any material change to what was planned, and capture what those activities found. It is the criterion most often answered with a list of review dates, which records that assurance occurred and not what it was worth.

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- [Skip to learning content](#) es, internal and external, and whether each happened.

- Where an activity was dropped, deferred or substituted, give the reason — a changed plan is fine, an unexplained one is not.
- Record the key findings and what was done about them, not just that a review took place.
- For a Strong rating, assess whether the assurance was any use: which recommendations changed the delivery, and which were noted and left.
- Assurance findings are also a source of lessons, and the standard expects the lessons section to draw on them.

Worked example. 'Gate 4 review conducted 12 March; Gate 6 review conducted 4 June' is a record of attendance. 'Gate 4 recommended splitting the integration release; adopted, and the second release absorbed the identity broker change without a further slip. Gate 6 recommended a benefits owner for B6; not resolved at closure and carried as R4' tells a reader whether the money spent on assurance bought anything.

Assurance and audit are different readers

They are routinely conflated, and the difference changes who you are writing for. Assurance is advice to the person accountable, given while there is still time to act — Gateway exists to help an SRO deliver. Audit is independent examination reported to others, usually after the fact, and its finding is about the entity rather than about you. A closure report is read by both, at different times, for different purposes.

- Write assurance responses to be useful; write the record to be testable. They are not in tension, and they are not the same task.
- An assurance recommendation not acted on is itself something a later audit will look at.
- Internal audit follow-up asks whether the closure commitments were kept, not whether the report was well written.
- The three-lines model is a useful check: management owns it, oversight functions monitor it, internal audit independently examines it. A closure report feeds all three.

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TWO DIFFERENT READERS

	Assurance	Audit
Reports to	The accountable officer	The entity's audit committee, Parliament
Timing	During, in time to change the outcome	After, on a sample
Question	Will this succeed, and what would help?	Is what was reported supported?
Consequence	Recommendations to the SRO	A finding against the entity

Worked example. A Gate 6 reviewer asks what would improve the outcome from here. An ANAO auditor asks what supports the number on page four. Answering the second well is what protects the entity; answering the first well is what protects the benefit.

Check yourself

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE	WHAT USUALLY HAPPENS	THE TELL
The extract, the query and the definition are retained with a named holder, and would answer an audit in two years.	The claim is supported by a dashboard in a workspace scheduled for deletion, and an email from the analyst.	Ask what would answer this question after the system is turned off. If the answer is a person, it is not evidence.

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Worked cases

The payments platform uplift

A \$47m program that delivered, and nearly could not prove it

A three-year platform program met its delivery commitments and wrote a closure report that would not have survived audit. The corrections made in the final six weeks are the substance of this case.

Stage 1 — The draft that said nothing

The first draft ran to 34 pages and stated that the program 'successfully delivered the agreed scope within the revised funding envelope, achieving improved payment processing outcomes'. The reviewer asked one question: if the incoming Deputy Secretary reads only this, what will they now do differently? Nobody could answer.

Reviewer note, 12 June:

"Three questions this document should answer and does not:

1. What did we promise in 2023, and did we deliver it?
2. Who owns the \$6.2m annual saving from 1 July?
3. What should the next platform program do differently?

Everything else is context."

Notice. The test of a closure report is not compliance with a template. It is whether a reader who was not there makes a different decision than they would have without it.

Stage 2 — Finding the original baseline

The program had been rebaselined twice. Reporting against the second revision produced 'delivered on budget'. Reporting against the original 2023 approval produced 'delivered at \$47.3m against \$38.1m approved'. Both were true. The team recorded the chain: original, revision one (Mar 2025, scope addition of the reconciliation module, +\$5.4m), revision two (Nov 2025, integration rework following the identity broker change, +\$3.8m).

Approved 2023 baseline:	\$38.1m	
Revision 1 (Mar 2025):	\$43.5m	scope addition – reconciliation module
Revision 2 (Nov 2025):	\$47.3m	integration rework – identity broker change
Final 2025 baseline:	\$47.3m	
Final 2023 baseline:	\$38.1m	
Final uplift:	\$9.2m	(+24%)

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Notice. Showing the chain costs nothing and pre-empts the finding. The +24% was always going to be discoverable; disclosing it made every other number in the report credible.

Stage 3 — The benefit nobody owned

The largest benefit — \$6.2m annually from reduced manual reconciliation — was allocated to 'Payments Operations Branch'. The team applied the four conditions and found three failures: no named individual, no evidence of agreement, and a measurement that depended on a reporting view built by the program. Only the influence test passed. They wrote it up as unresolved and took it to the SRO.

Benefit B1 — \$6.2m p.a. from FY2027-28

Named individual	x	'Payments Operations Branch'
Has agreed	x	no record of the figure being put to them
Can influence	✓	branch controls the reconciliation process
Has measurement	x	depends on view PAY-VW-22, built by the program

Status: NOT TRANSFERRED. Escalated to SRO 19 June.

Notice. Three of the four conditions failed and the item would still have been signed off as 'handed to Payments Operations'. The four-condition test is what turns an assumption into a visible gap.

Stage 4 — The evidence that was about to be deleted

The decommissioning plan deleted the program's analytics workspace 30 days after closure. Everything supporting the baseline — the pre-change reconciliation volumes, the error rates, the effort sampling — lived there. The team extracted the baseline datasets to the department's records store, wrote the queries and definitions alongside them, and named the Assistant Director, Performance Reporting as holder.

Retained to RM store REC-2026-0881, holder: AD Performance Reporting

- baseline-reconciliation-volumes-2023-2026.csv
- baseline-error-rates-2023-2026.csv
- effort-sample-2024.csv
- queries.sql — the extraction logic, commented
- definitions.md — what each metric counts and excludes

Retention: 7 years, per entity schedule.

Notice. The measurement had not happened yet and the evidence for it was 30 days from deletion. Retention is a closure decision because closure is when the window shuts.

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The rewritten report opened with a one-page statement of promised, delivered and gap, followed by a section headed 'What we did not

achieve'. It stated the \$9.2m cost overrun against original approval, the unresolved ownership of B1, and a straggling benefit at 60 per cent of forecast. No compensating successes appeared in that section; they had their own.

What we did not achieve

1. Cost. \$47.3m against \$38.1m approved (+24%). Both revisions were approved; the original commitment was still exceeded.
2. Benefit B1 ownership. Not transferred at closure. Action with SR0; acceptance scheduled for the August Payments Committee.
3. Benefit B4 (error-rate reduction) is measuring at 60% of forecast at 4 months. Cause not yet established. Under review by the benefit owner, reporting December.

Notice. The section is three items and eleven lines. It is also the only part of the report the Deputy Secretary quoted back — because it was the only part that told her something she could act on.

Stage 6 — One lesson worth the whole document

The \$3.8m integration rework followed an identity broker token-lifetime change that the program was not notified about. The team wrote it as a four-part lesson with the ratio, and published it to the departmental lessons pool classed against platform integrations with shared identity services — not into the program's own folder.

LP-2026-204 · Class: platform integration, shared identity services
Context: any build depending on the whole-of-department identity broker.
Event: token lifetime changed Sep 2025 without notification to consuming programs. Session handling broke in UAT.
Cost: integration rework 3.4× the original estimate; \$3.8m; 11-week schedule impact.
Action: register as a consuming system with Platform Identity and request change notification at design, not at integration.
There is no automatic notification list – you must ask.

Notice. 'Manage external dependencies more actively' and this entry describe the same event. Only one of them tells the next team to send an email in week two.

Nothing about the delivery changed in those six weeks. What changed was whether anyone could tell — and whether the \$6.2m benefit had an owner when the team walked out. The report went from 34 pages nobody would act on to 19 pages with three items

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The register that was switched off twice

Eleven years of records, a lapsed subscription, and the fortnight that saved them

A licensing register was replaced and decommissioned. The first attempt would have destroyed Commonwealth records without authority; the second was sequenced properly and cost three weeks.

Stage 1 — The decommissioning plan that was a cancellation plan

The plan had three steps: migrate active licences to the new platform, notify users, cancel the hosting subscription at end of quarter. Nobody had asked what happened to the eleven years of superseded, refused and lapsed applications that were not being migrated because they were not active.

Decommissioning plan v1.2 – extract

1. Migrate active licence records (approx 8,400)
 2. Notify users; redirect the URL
 3. Cancel hosting subscription 30 June – saving \$240k p.a.
- Records disposition: not addressed.

Notice. The plan was competent about everything it considered. What it did not consider was the majority of the data, because 'not active' had been quietly read as 'not needed'.

Stage 2 — Sentencing, which nobody had done

Information governance was asked to sentence the holdings properly. Three different retention periods applied. Refused applications carried a longer period than anyone expected because of the review and appeal history attached to them, and a small set had potential archival value and could not be destroyed at all.

Sentencing outcome

Active licences	migrate to new platform, retention continues
Lapsed/superseded	7 years from last action – 61,300 records
Refused + appeal history	longer period applies – 4,180 records
Pre-2015 policy files	potential archival value – refer to NAA
Destroy now under authority: NIL	

Notice. Nothing at all could be destroyed on the planned date. The assumption that a decommissioning date is a technical decision was the whole error, and it was one question away from being caught.

Save the data, then read it back

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CSV with the DDL schema, all code and lookup tables, and a written data dictionary. Then they read it back

and reconciled it against the live system. Row counts matched on every table but one: the appeals table was short by 312 rows, because the export query joined on a status code that had been retired in 2019 and left nulls behind.

Reconciliation – export v1

```
applications      61,300 / 61,300   OK
licences          8,400 /  8,400   OK
appeals           3,868 /  4,180  SHORT 312
Cause: join on status_code, retired value 'RV' not mapped.
Re-exported and re-reconciled: 4,180 / 4,180 OK.
```

Notice. An export that runs cleanly is not an export that is complete. The 312 records were the ones with the longest retention period and the highest likelihood of being requested.

Stage 4 — The subscription that was already cancelled

The cancellation had been lodged with the vendor two weeks earlier, effective 30 June, with data deletion 30 days after. The team reinstated for one quarter at \$60k to complete the export, verification and archival referral. The finance position was corrected at the same time: \$180k of the expected saving was reversed out of the following year's budget submission, which had already been lodged assuming it.

Financial correction

```
Reinstate hosting Q1 FY27      $60k unbudgeted
Saving reversed from submission $180k (3 quarters, not 4)
Warranty on migration tooling expires 12 Nov 2027,
                                holder: AD Platform Services
Note: saving had been booked before disposition was resolved.
```

Notice. The saving had been promised to a budget process before anyone knew whether the system could lawfully be switched off. That is the ordinary sequence, and it is backwards.

Stage 5 — The fortnight with the integrations off

Integrations and access were revoked, and the system was left running but unreachable for fourteen days. On day four, a monthly compliance report failed. It drew licence status directly from the register and had been built by a different branch three years earlier; nobody in the project knew it existed.

Integration blackout log

```
2020-06-04 10:00:00 Known integrations disabled
2020-06-04 10:00:00 Monthly (COMP-114) unable to source
2020-06-04 10:00:00 licence_status. owner: Regulatory Branch. Not in
2020-06-04 10:00:00 any dependency register. Not known to the project.
```

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Day 9 no further failures
Day 14 proceed to release infrastructure

Notice. One undocumented consumer, found while the system could still be turned back on. Deleting on the original schedule would have found it in the same way and at a very different price.

Stage 6 — Writing down what nearly happened

The closure report stated plainly that the approved decommissioning plan would have destroyed approximately 65,000 Commonwealth records without authority, that this was caught by a question rather than by a control, and that no step in the entity's process would have caught it. The recommendation was a mandatory sentencing gate before any decommissioning date can be set.

What nearly went wrong

Plan v1.2 would have destroyed approx 65,000 Commonwealth records without authority on 30 July. Detected on 12 June by a question at design review, not by any control. No approval step in the current process requires records disposition to be resolved before a decommissioning date is committed.

R1 (accepted): sentencing sign-off from Information Governance is a precondition of setting any decommissioning date, and of booking any saving arising from one.

Notice. The valuable output was not the preserved records. It was the sentence saying the control did not exist — which changed the process for every future decommissioning in the entity.

The saving was real, the migration was competent, and the plan was endorsed by people who knew what they were doing. It would still have destroyed sixty-five thousand records that the entity was legally obliged to keep, on a date chosen because a subscription renewed then. Nothing in the process would have stopped it.

The grants portal that closed twice

What an unresolved handover costs eighteen months later

A well-delivered service was handed over on paper and not in practice. The failure surfaced during an incident, and the second closure — done pro

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Stage 1 — The handover that passed

The portal went live in March, the handover pack was signed in April, and the delivery team dispersed in May. The pack was genuinely good. Nobody tested whether the receiving team could use it, and the receiving team had not tried, because nothing had gone wrong yet.

```
Handover checklist, 22 April – all items ✓
Architecture documentation           ✓
Runbooks (12)                        ✓
Support model agreed                 ✓
Walkthrough delivered and recorded  ✓
Signed: Delivery Manager / Operations Manager
```

Notice. Every input was complete. The checklist confirmed that documents existed, which is not the same question as whether anyone could act on them.

Stage 2 — Eighteen months of quiet dependency

Between May and the following November, the operations team contacted the former technical lead — by then in another division — roughly twice a month. Configuration questions, a certificate renewal, an unexplained batch failure. Each was resolved in under an hour. The dependency never appeared in any report because nothing ever broke.

Notice. The informal channel is what makes an inadequate handover survivable, and therefore invisible. The cost is not paid until the person stops answering.

Stage 3 — The incident

In November the nightly reconciliation failed four nights running. The former technical lead had left the department in September. It took the operations team nine hours to establish that a retry loop was masking an upstream timeout, and that the threshold was set in a config file the runbooks did not mention. The post-incident review named the real cause as the untested handover, not the timeout.

```
Post-incident review, INC-2026-4471
Immediate cause: upstream provider timeout; retry threshold in
app.config exhausted after 3 attempts.
Contributing:    threshold not documented in any runbook.
Root cause:      handover was assessed on document completeness,
not on receiving-team capability. Dependency on departed staff
substituted for documentation for 18 months and was never visible.
Time to restore: 9h 14m. Comparable documented fault: <1h.
```

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caused by the timeout. They were caused by eighteen months in which nobody had to find out what they

did not know.

Stage 4 — Closing it properly

The operations manager funded eleven weeks of a contractor who had worked on the original build, with one instruction: work through the real tasks with the operations team, and document what they had to ask.

Forty-one gaps were found. Nine were significant. The config threshold was one of the smaller ones.

Rediscovery log – 41 items, 11 weeks

Significant (9):

- retry threshold and upstream timeout behaviour
- certificate inventory – 3 certs, no owner, no renewal calendar
- batch window dependency (fails if run after 02:00)
- manual reconciliation procedure – undocumented entirely
- identity broker token lifetime assumption
- 4 further

Moderate (14) • Minor (18)

Notice. Forty-one gaps in a handover that scored 100 per cent on its checklist. The gap was never in the documents; it was in the test.

Stage 5 — What the second closure report said

The second report was explicit: the original closure was completed on document completeness and should not have been accepted. It recorded the cost — nine hours of outage, eleven weeks of contractor time, roughly \$180k — and recommended that closure acceptance in the division require a demonstrated task, not a signed pack.

Recommendation R1 (accepted, effective 1 Feb):

Handover acceptance requires the receiving team to complete two routine tasks and one diagnostic task with the delivery team unavailable. Questions raised become the handover backlog.

Sign-off follows completion, not documentation.

Cost of the original approach: \$180k and one Sev-2 outage.

Notice. The recommendation is one paragraph and changes what 'handover complete' means for every subsequent project in the division. That is the return a closure report can produce, and almost never does.

The delivery was good. The documentation was good. The handover was signed by two competent managers who had done everything the process asked. It still cost \$180k and a Sev-2,

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ing that mattered — whether the
the people leaving.

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Templates

Marked claim

[Measured / Estimated / Asserted]: [statement with magnitude]. [Definition, period, sample, source] or [assumption] or [basis].

Example. Measured: median lodgement-to-decision time fell from 14 to 9 days. Definition: system-generated lodgement to decision timestamp, excluding withdrawn applications. Q1 2026 (n=3,880) vs Q3 2026 (n=4,102). Source: CMS-RPT-114.

The label is not a hedge. It is what makes your measured claims believable when a reader meets your asserted ones.

Baseline chain

Original approved: [\$X, date]. Revision N: [\$Y, date, reason]. Final actual: [\$Z].
Against original: [+/- amount, per cent].

Example. Original approved: \$38.1m (Aug 2023). Revision 1: \$43.5m (Mar 2025, reconciliation module added). Revision 2: \$47.3m (Nov 2025, integration rework after identity broker change). Final actual: \$47.3m. Against original approval: +\$9.2m (+24%).

Disclosing the chain pre-empts the finding. The variance is discoverable anyway; volunteering it buys credibility for everything else.

Benefit transfer record

Benefit: [what, magnitude, from when]. Owner: [name, role]. Agreed: [when and where].
Influence: [driver they control]. Measurement: [source that already exists, cycle].

Example. Benefit: \$2.4m p.a. reduced avoidable contact, from FY2027-28. Owner: Director, Provider Support Branch. Agreed: 14 July governance meeting, minuted. Influence: controls triage and support staffing; note contact volume is partly driven by notification policy owned by Policy Branch — joint dependency recorded. Measurement: monthly contact volumes, standing Service Performance pack, reviewed each December.

Run the four conditions. Any that fails is written as a gap with an action, no

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Self-assessment against the seven criteria

For each criterion: rating (Strong / Emerging / Nil) · what the report currently says · what it would take to move up a level.

Example. C2 Schedule — EMERGING. The report has a milestone table with planned, rebaselined and actual dates. It does not say why integration slipped 35 weeks or what it cost. To reach Strong: add the identity broker token change as the cause, with the 11-week and \$3.8m impact, and note the knock-on to public release. C5 Assurance — NIL. Gate 4 and Gate 6 dates are listed and nothing else. To reach Emerging: record the findings of each and what was done about them. To reach Strong: say which recommendations changed delivery and which were noted and left.

Do this on the draft, before it goes to the SRO. Rating yourself Strong on all seven is not an outcome, it is a tell — and the reviewer reads the same standard you do.

Document purpose

This report closes [project] and transfers [what] to named owners. It supports [whose decision] and [whose decision].

Example. This report closes the Provider Status project and transfers six benefits, four residual risks and one unresolved dependency to named owners. It supports the SRO's decision to stand down programme governance, and Finance's treatment of \$47.3m of capitalised and expensed cost.

If the sentence would be true of any closure report, it is not a purpose statement. Name this project's decisions and this project's readers.

Objective, outcome and key result

Objective (as originally written): [text] – [achieved / partially / not]. Business outcome: [change], [measured or estimated] at [figure] against baseline [figure]. Key result: [metric], target [x], actual [y].

Example. Objective: 'Provide providers with self-service visibility of application status.' Achieved. Business outcome: reduce avoidable support contact — measured 18% reduction against a 40% target. Key result: contacts per application, target 0.6, actual 0.83.

Re [Skip to learning content](#) delivered while its outcome did not, you have, and merging the levels destroys it.

Outstanding item transfer row

[Risk / Issue / Dependency / Action] [ref]: [description]. Owner: [name, role]. [Rating or impact]. [Treatment or path]. Destination: [register, ref]. Review: [when].

Example. Risk R1: identity broker token lifetime may change without notice, breaking session handling. Owner: Assistant Director, Platform Services. Rating: medium. Treatment: registered as a consuming system with Platform Identity, notification requested. Destination: Platform Services risk register PS-R-118. Review: December committee.

No row owned by a team, a branch or the project. If an item genuinely has no owner, write UNTRANSFERRED and put it in front of the signatory.

Follow-on action

[Ref]: [unfinished work]. Owner: [name, role]. Due: [date]. If not done: [consequence]. Origin: issue [ref] from this project.

Example. A3: revise the notification wording that continues to generate avoidable calls. Owner: Director, Eligibility Policy. Due: 30 November. If not done: the contact-reduction benefit stays at 18% against a 40% target and the benefit owner cannot act, because the driver sits outside their control. Origin: issue I7, raised March, not resolved at closure.

Every open issue at closure is closed, formally accepted, or becomes one of these. If you cannot name an owner, say so on the page the signatory reads.

Recommendation

[Ref]: [what this entity should change]. Directed to: [process owner]. Basis: [what happened here]. Status: [accepted / not accepted / pending].

Example. R1: sentencing sign-off from Information Governance should be a precondition of setting any decommissioning date, and of booking any saving arising from one. Directed to: Assistant Secretary, Delivery Assurance. Basis: the approved plan for the licensing register would have destroyed approximately 65,000 Commonwealth records; no approval step required records disposition to be resolved first. Status: accepted, effective 1 February.

A recommendation is about this entity's process; a lesson is about future projects. A recommendation as a lesson sends it to a pool of lessons.

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Quality and completion

Completion criteria: [n] agreed, [n] met, [n] waived by [who]. Quality: [defects by severity accepted into production, owner], [performance], [accessibility], [security].

Example. Completion criteria: 7 agreed, 6 met, 1 waived (bulk export deferred) by the SRO on 3 June. Quality: 14 known defects accepted into production, 2 at severity 3, all owned in the platform backlog; peak load tested to 3x forecast; accessibility audited at WCAG 2.1 AA with two outstanding AAA items; no open security findings above low.

Quality is not scope. 'Passed UAT' records that a meeting happened; this records whether the thing works under real conditions.

Artefact index row

[Artefact]: [what it is]. Location: [where, precisely]. Owner: [name, role]. [Record with retention obligation? period and authority.]

Example. Data dictionary and export schema: column definitions, units and exclusions for the retained case export. Location: records store REC-2026-0881. Owner: Assistant Director, Information Governance. Commonwealth record, retained 7 years under the programme administration authority.

Include what people forget: architecture decisions, test evidence, contracts, the benefits plan. A name with no location is not an index.

Closure agreement

Signed by [name, role], confirming that the [benefits / risks / obligations] recorded in sections [x] to [y] have been accepted by the owners named there. Date: [date]. [Exceptions, if any.]

Example. Signed by the Senior Responsible Officer, confirming that the benefits, risks and obligations recorded in sections 6 to 9 have been accepted by the owners named there. Exception: Risk R4 (data quality in migrated records) remains untransferred and is referred to the Deputy Secretary for allocation.

Tie the signature to the transfers. 'Signed to confirm project closure' attests to something everyone could already see.

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Four-part lesson

Context: [class of work this applies to]. Event: [what happened, with magnitude]. Cost: [schedule, dollars, or ratio]. Action: [what to do differently, concretely].

Example. Context: any build depending on the whole-of-department identity broker. Event: token lifetime changed without notification to consuming programs; session handling broke in UAT. Cost: integration rework 3.4× estimate, \$3.8m, 11 weeks. Action: register as a consuming system with Platform Identity at design and request change notification — there is no automatic list, you must ask.

If the action could be written before the project started, it is a sentiment. The action should only be knowable because of what happened.

Shortfall statement

[What was committed, in original units]. [What was achieved]. [Shortfall]. Cause: [forecast error or delivery failure, with the distinction stated]. Recorded: [where the lesson sits].

Example. The business case forecast \$3.1m annual savings from FY2027-28. Measured at nine months: \$1.2m annualised. Shortfall \$1.9m against the original commitment. Cause is forecast error rather than delivery failure — the system performs to specification; take-up is 41% against a forecast 85%. The forecast used the 2023 mandatory-channel rollout as its comparator for an opt-in service. Recorded as LP-2026-118.

No compensating success in this passage. Successes are reported elsewhere, on their own merits.

Evidence retention record

Claim supported: [which]. Retained: [files]. Method: [query or calculation, where]. Definition: [what is counted and excluded]. Holder: [name, role]. Period: [per which schedule].

Example. Claim: B1 baseline reconciliation volumes. Retained to RM store REC-2026-0881: baseline volumes CSV, error rates CSV, effort sample CSV, queries.sql, definitions.md. Holder: Assistant Director, Performance Reporting. Retention 7 years per entity schedule. Source system PAY-ANALYTICS decommissioned 30 days post-closure.

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ed off.

Handover capability test

Task: [a real routine task]. Performed by: [receiving team]. Delivery team: unavailable. Expected: [time]. Actual: [time]. Questions raised: [list – this is the backlog].

Example. Task: apply a configuration change to the notification threshold and deploy to test. Performed by: two operations engineers. Delivery team unavailable for the day. Expected 30 minutes; actual 4 hours. Questions raised: where is the threshold set (undocumented, found in source); which pipeline deploys config (runbook names a decommissioned pipeline); who approves a test deployment (unassigned). Three handover backlog items.

Run this before closure, not after. The questions raised are the handover you have not done yet.

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Field guide

The Gateway gates

Gateway runs a series of short independent reviews across a proposal's lifecycle. Gate 6 is the one closure work is written for, but knowing where it sits explains what it is checking against.

Gate 0 — Business need

Strategic assessment. Whether the proposal addresses a real need and fits the entity's direction.

Gate 1 — Business case

Whether the preferred option is deliverable and the benefits are credible. The benefits claimed here are what Gate 6 tests.

Gate 2 — Procurement strategy

Whether the approach to market will deliver the intended outcome.

Gate 3 — Investment decision

Readiness to commit. Whether the arrangements to deliver and to realise benefits are in place.

Gate 4 — Readiness for service

Whether the organisation is ready to operate what is being delivered — including the receiving business.

Gate 5 — Benefits realisation

Operational review after service commencement, checking benefits are beginning to appear.

Gate 6 — Closure

Close-out of delivery into operations, and assessment of whether the purpose and benefits of the investment were delivered and continue to be harvested.

When Gateway applies

The thresholds trigger a recommendation; they are not the only route in. Finance may recommend review for high-risk proposals, and entities may run internal equivalents below the thresholds.

Procurement or infrastructure

Total estimated cost of \$30 million or more.

ICT-enabled projects

Total estimated cost of \$30 million or more including an ICT component of at least \$10 million.

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Total estimated cost of \$30 million or more.

Entity scope

Non-corporate Commonwealth entities. Defence Capability Plan projects assessed under the Kinnaird two-pass process are excluded.

Interaction with ICT Investment Approval

Where both apply, Gates 0 and 1 are not mandatory; Gateway commences after Government approval and focuses on implementation.

Reader quick reference

What each audience opens the report to find, and what they do if it is not there.

Senior Responsible Officer

Whether benefits are on track and who owns them. If absent: signs it anyway, and the benefits governance quietly lapses.

Chief Financial Officer

Final costs, asset recognition, settled obligations. If absent: goes to the ledger and ignores the narrative.

Next delivery team

Specific, transferable detail. If absent: cannot obtain it anywhere else, and repeats the failure at the same cost.

Receiving operational team

How to run, support and change it. If absent: contacts departed staff until they stop replying.

ANAO or internal audit

Whether claims are supported by evidence. If absent: tests it anyway and raises a finding against the entity.

Financial and contractual closeout checklist

The items that have a hard deadline and a statutory audience. Everything here is cheap to settle while the team remembers and expensive to reconstruct afterwards.

Invoices and accruals

All costs recorded in the correct period; anything performed but not invoiced is accrued with a stated basis.

Open commitments

Purchase orders closed, or carried with a documented reason and an owner.

Capitalisation

Tested against what was actually delivered. Abandoned options, training and most post-go-live defect work are expensed.

What to skip to learning content

Cleared to asset or expense. An unclear balance becomes unexplained the moment the team disperses.

Final acceptance

Signed because obligations were met, not because the project ended.
Starts warranties, releases retentions, closes the defects window.

Warranty / defects liability

End date recorded and a named holder who will act on it. The most commonly lost entitlement at closure.

Retentions and holdbacks

Settled, or the position documented with the condition for release.

IP, source and data

Actually delivered, not licensed in principle. Check before acceptance, not after.

Transition-out

What the supplier must still do, by when, and who will enforce it.

Surviving obligations

Confidentiality, records access and audit rights typically continue past termination. List them with end dates.

Recurring costs

Licences, hosting and support moved to a funded budget line whose holder has accepted them.

Decommissioning sequence

In order, with the reversible checkpoint before anything irreversible. Data in a government business system is a Commonwealth record; the disposition question comes before the date, not after it.

1. Sentence the records

What must be kept, for how long, under which authority. Everything downstream depends on this, and it is the step routinely skipped.

2. Decide the retention approach

Open-format export with schema and dictionary for most cases; migration where a successor fits; referral to the National Archives where archival value applies.

3. Export

Every table, with DDL schema, code and lookup tables, and a plain-English data dictionary covering units and exclusions.

4. Verify by reading it back

Reconcile row counts and control totals against the live system. An export that ran cleanly is not necessarily complete.

5. Retain closure evidence separately

Baseline extracts, queries and metric definitions, with a named holder
ou

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6. Check downstream consumers

Reports, interfaces and extracts built by other areas. The dependency register is usually incomplete.

7. Revoke access and integrations

The reversible checkpoint. Leave the system running but unreachable for a fortnight and see what breaks.

8. Release infrastructure

Only now: delete data, close accounts, cancel subscriptions. The first irreversible step in the sequence.

9. State the disposition of what it replaced

Still running? Name the owner, the cost, the stop date, and which system is the system of record.

The seven criteria, and what Strong means

The DTA standard for digital and ICT-enabled project closure reports. Agencies self-assess each criterion as Strong, Emerging or Nil before finalising. Emerging records what happened; Strong explains why, and what followed. Read the right-hand column as the only thing standing between the two.

1. Scope

Emerging: overview, objectives and scope as agreed in the business case, performance against it, any adjustments recorded, and the original business case attached. Strong adds the rationale for each adjustment and its impact.

2. Schedule

Emerging: performance against the agreed schedule including key milestones. Strong adds the rationale for and impact of every slip, milestone movement and change request.

3. Outcomes and benefits

Emerging: achievement of outcomes against the benefits management plan, with the percentage of benefits realised, expected date of realisation and transition of benefit owners, plus any formal changes to benefits. Strong adds an agreed plan for transferring ongoing benefit management and its governance to the owners after closure.

4. Budget

Emerging: final budget position against the agreed budget, a breakdown of performance against it, and any changes recorded. Strong adds the rationale for each change — including Movement of Funds requests and additional funding — and its impact, including on the wider agency.

5. Assurance

Emerging: completion of internal and external assurance activities per the DTA, the rationale for any material change, and key outcomes. Strong adds an assessment of whether the assurance was effective and worth its cost.

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6. Transition to BAU

Emerging: transition arrangements, the owners of any deliverable or scope component left incomplete, and a register of ongoing risks and issues transferring to BAU. Strong adds sustainment funding plans and the impact of handing incomplete work over.

7. Lessons learned

Emerging: key lessons including those from assurance, how they were identified, how they will be applied to in-flight and future projects, and the lessons learned register attached. Strong links each lesson to the delivery challenge that produced it and addresses the source of the issue.

The pattern

Across all seven, Strong is the same move: not only what changed, but why it changed and what it cost. If your draft states facts without causes, it is Emerging.

Which template

DTA templates exist for Tier 1 and Tier 2 projects under the Investment Oversight Framework, and a lighter one for Tier 3 and smaller work. Agencies may use their own template provided it meets the criteria.

Standard closure report sections

The headings most departmental templates use, what each is actually for, and how each is usually failed. Templates vary; the questions behind the headings do not.

Document purpose

The decisions this report supports and who must take them. Failed by restating the title.

Project overview

Orientation for a reader who was not there — problem, scope, dates, cost, internal name and funding reference. Failed by pasting the 2023 business case.

Objectives

What the project set out to do, quoted as originally written, marked achieved / partial / not. Failed by quoting the revised wording.

Business outcomes

The change that justified the spend, with its baseline and whether measured or estimated. Failed by restating the objective.

Key results

The measures, each with target and actual. Failed by listing metrics that never had targets.

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Plan reason. Failed when every actual equals plan — that is a rebaselined table.

Financial summary

Original approved, revisions dated and reasoned, final actual, variance against original; capital and operating split; recurring cost and its new budget line. Failed by reporting against the revision.

Benefits realisation

Each benefit with a named owner who agreed, can influence the driver, and has a measurement that already exists.

Outstanding risks, issues, dependencies, actions

A transfer table, not a status log. Each row: individual, destination register, review date — or the word UNTRANSFERRED.

Lessons learned

Context, event with magnitude, cost, action — published to a pool someone with that problem would search.

Handover / transition

Support, change authority, run cost, records obligations, benefits measurement, each to a named holder. Tested, not just signed.

Project artefacts

An index with location and owner for each, marking which are records with retention obligations.

Completion criteria

The conditions agreed for calling it done, each marked met, partial or waived — and by whom. Failed by 'all deliverables completed'.

Quality / product status

Defect counts and severities, performance under load, accessibility conformance, security position. Failed by 'passed UAT', which reports a meeting.

Team performance

Resourcing model, vacancy and turnover, reliance on individuals, what you would staff differently. Failed by a list of names and thanks.

Stakeholder feedback

Who was asked, how, response rate, and the dissent. Unanimous approval means the wrong people were asked.

Follow-on actions

Every open issue closed, formally accepted, or carried to a named owner with a date. 'Ongoing' is not a state.

Recommendations

Directed at this entity's process, named to someone who can act, with whether they were accepted. Distinct from lessons.

Agreement on closure

Signature attesting that the transfers described were accepted by the owner. [Skip to learning content](#) stated on the page.

Phrases that signal a weak claim

Constructions an experienced reader treats as flags. Removing them is not a style preference — each one marks a number the writer chose not to state.

Successfully delivered

'Successfully' does no work. Say what was delivered, when, against which baseline.

Broadly in line with expectations

Missed, by an amount not stated. Give the figure and the expectation.

Within the revised budget

Over the original. Report against both with the revision chain.

Stakeholders were engaged throughout

Meetings occurred. Name the group, the decision and the date.

Lessons have been captured

A workshop happened. Say how many, where they are published, and give one.

Improved outcomes for users

Unmeasured unless a figure follows. Mark it asserted or give the measure.

Handed over to operations

Which of the six transfers, to whom, and did the receiving team demonstrate it?

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Glossary

Each entry names the body of practice the term comes from. Epics, features and Program Increments are not Scrum terms, and the DES delivery phases are not the DTA service phases.

Annual performance statements GOVERNMENT	The statements a Commonwealth entity publishes in its annual report, reporting performance against the purposes set out in its corporate plan. Audited, which is why a closure claim that flows into them can be tested.
Asserted claim GENERAL	A statement resting on informed judgement with no measurement behind it. Legitimate in a closure report if labelled as such; corrosive if written in the same confident past tense as a measurement.
Assurance review GOVERNMENT	A short, intensive independent review at a defined point in a proposal's lifecycle, providing the Senior Responsible Officer with advice and early identification of areas needing corrective action.
Baseline GENERAL	The approved position against which delivery is measured. The useful one is the baseline approved when the investment decision was made, not the most recent revision.
Benefit owner GOVERNMENT	The named individual accountable for realising and reporting a specific benefit after closure. Must have agreed, be able to influence the driver, and have a measurement that will exist without new funded work.
Benefits realisation GOVERNMENT	The process of achieving and measuring the benefits promised in a business case. Occurs in the operational business after delivery, which is why it cannot be completed as a project activity.
Benefits realisation management plan GOVERNMENT	The document setting out what each benefit is, who owns it, how and when it will be measured, and what happens if it is not realised.
Closure report GOVERNMENT	The record produced at the end of delivery stating what was promised, what was delivered, what it cost, what was learned, and who now owns everything that outlives the project.
Decommissioning GENERAL	Retiring the systems and environments used during delivery. The most common cause of an evidence chain breaking, because the data supporting a benefit claim goes with the system.
Estimated claim GENERAL	A figure derived from a model rather than measured. Sound practice when the assumptions it depends on are stated, so a reader can judge whether they still hold.
Evidence chain GENERAL	Claim, method, data, definition, approval. What an auditor follows from a reported figure until they reach primary data or run out.
Forecast error GENERAL	A shortfall caused by the original estimate being wrong rather than by a change in requirements. Distinguishing the two is what makes a shortfall useful to the next business case.

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Gate 6	GOVERNMENT	The Benefits Realisation gate in the Gateway process. Assesses whether the investment delivered its purpose and benefits, and whether benefit harvesting continues after closure.
Gateway Review Process	GOVERNMENT	The Department of Finance process of independent reviews at critical points across a high-risk proposal's lifecycle, for non-corporate Commonwealth entities above defined financial thresholds.
Handover	GENERAL	The transfer of operational support, change authority, run costs, residual risks, benefits measurement and records obligations from delivery to the receiving parts of the business.
Known fragility	GENERAL	The parts of a delivered system the team knows are weak — timing dependencies, retry loops, unexplained configuration. Rarely documented, because recording it reads as confession.
Lessons learned	GOVERNMENT	Transferable findings from delivery. Usable only when they carry context, a specific event with magnitude, a cost, and an action a future team could put in a plan.
Measured claim	GENERAL	A figure from data collected before and after, using the same definition both times. The only kind of claim that supports itself without qualification.
New Policy Proposal	GOVERNMENT	A proposal put to Government for funding. Where high risk and above the financial thresholds, Finance may recommend it be subject to the Gateway Review Process.
PGPA Act	GOVERNMENT	The Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013, which establishes the Commonwealth performance framework requiring entities to measure and report performance against their purposes.
Post-implementation review	GOVERNMENT	A review conducted after delivery — typically 6 to 12 months post-closure — to assess whether benefits are being realised and to capture findings for future work.
Capitalisation	GOVERNMENT	Recording spend as an asset rather than an expense. Requires an identifiable asset the entity controls and will benefit from — which abandoned options, training and most post-go-live defect work are not.
Commonwealth record	GOVERNMENT	Information created or received in the course of Australian Government business, including data inside a business system. Governed by the Archives Act 1983; cannot be destroyed without authority.
Continuing access	GOVERNMENT	The obligation to keep retained records readable for the prescribed period — not merely stored. A backup requiring software the entity no longer licenses does not satisfy it.
Defects liability period	GENERAL	The window after final acceptance during which the supplier must remedy defects at their cost. Worthless without a named holder and a recorded end date.
Final acceptance		Final acceptance confirming contracted deliverables were received and met the contract. Starts warranty periods, releases retentions and closes the defects window.

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Business outcome GOVERNMENT	The change in the world that justified the investment, as distinct from what the project set out to build. Reported with its baseline, and often the place where a delivered objective turns out not to have moved anything.
Closure agreement GENERAL	The signed act ending the project. Meaningful only when it attests that the transfers described in the report were accepted by the owners named — not merely that the project stopped.
Key result GENERAL	The measure that shows whether a business outcome occurred. Carries a target and an actual; without a target it was a metric, not a key result.
Objective GENERAL	What the project set out to do, quoted as originally written. Achievement of an objective is not achievement of the outcome that justified it.
Project artefacts GENERAL	The outputs a project leaves behind — architecture decisions, data dictionaries, test evidence, contracts, benefits plans. Indexed with location and owner so a stranger can find them.
RAID GENERAL	Risks, assumptions, issues and dependencies. At closure it stops being a status log and becomes a transfer table: every open item accepted by a named person or visibly abandoned.
Completion criteria GENERAL	The conditions agreed at the outset for calling the project done. Reported at closure as met, partially met or waived — with who waived them — so that closure is a test rather than an opinion.
Follow-on action recommendation GENERAL	Unfinished work carried out of a closing project to a named owner with a date. The discipline is that every open issue at closure is closed, formally accepted, or converted to one — there is no 'ongoing'.
Recommendation GENERAL	A proposal directed at this entity about how it works, as distinct from a lesson aimed at future projects. A recommendation that changes a control is often the most valuable line in a closure report.
Assurance Plan GOVERNMENT	The plan agreed with the Digital Transformation Agency setting out the internal and external assurance activities a digital or ICT-enabled project will undergo. The closure report must record their completion — this is criterion 5 of the closure reporting standard.
Benefits management plan GOVERNMENT	The artefact recording each benefit, its owner, how and when it will be measured. Criterion 3 of the closure reporting standard measures the report against this plan, not against the business case narrative.
Closure reporting standard GOVERNMENT	The DTA standard for closure reports on Australian Government digital and ICT-enabled projects. Seven criteria, each self-assessed by the agency as Strong, Emerging or Nil before the report is finalised.
Investment Oversight Framework GOVERNMENT	The framework tiering Australian Government digital and ICT investments by size and complexity. The tier determines which closure report template applies — Tier 1 and 2 use the fuller template, Tier 3 a lighter one.

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Movement of Funds GOVERNMENT	A request to move approved funding between financial years. Named explicitly in the closure reporting standard: a Strong budget criterion gives the rationale for each such change and its impact, including on the wider agency.
Strong, Emerging, Nil GOVERNMENT	The three ratings in the closure reporting standard's self-assessment. Nil means the criterion is not addressed; Emerging records what happened; Strong explains why it happened and what followed from it.
Sustainment funding GOVERNMENT	The ongoing funding to operate and support what was delivered, after project funding ends. Required for a Strong rating on the transition criterion, alongside the impact of handing incomplete work to business as usual.
Records authority GOVERNMENT	An instrument issued by the National Archives giving permission to destroy, retain or transfer described records, and setting minimum retention periods.
Sentencing GOVERNMENT	Determining, against a records authority, which records must be kept, for how long, destroyed, or transferred. The first step in any decommissioning, because everything else depends on the answer.
System of record GENERAL	The authoritative source for a given set of data. Must be named explicitly when a replaced system stays running, or staff cannot know which copy governs.
Transition-out obligations GENERAL	What a supplier must still do after the engagement ends — deliver source code and documentation, support handover, provide records access. Frequently unenforced because nobody records the deadline.
Work in progress GOVERNMENT	Costs accumulated against a project not yet transferred to an asset or an expense. Left uncleared at closure it becomes an unexplained balance nobody can resolve later.
Reference class data GENERAL	Pooled estimate-versus-actual figures across comparable projects, used to forecast new work from what similar work actually cost rather than from what a team hopes.
Residual risk GENERAL	A risk that survives closure. Must transfer to a named owner in the entity's risk register, or it disappears from view without disappearing from existence.
Retention GOVERNMENT	Keeping the extract, method and definition behind a reported figure for long enough that the claim can still be tested. A design decision at closure, not an afterthought.
RMG 106 GOVERNMENT	Finance's Guidance on the Assurance Reviews Process — the operating guidance for Gateway, including the gates and what the Senior Responsible Officer is accountable for.
RMG 134	Finance's guidance on annual performance statements for

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Run cost	GENERAL	The recurring cost of operating a delivered system — licences, hosting, support. Must transfer to a funded budget line with a named holder, or a renewal lapses.
Senior Responsible Officer	GOVERNMENT	The individual accountable for a proposal achieving its objectives and realising its benefits, across the whole lifecycle including after delivery ends. The recipient of Gateway assurance.
Shortfall paragraph	GENERAL	A direct passage stating what was not achieved, by how much against the original commitment, why, and where the lesson is recorded — unaccompanied by a compensating success.
Traceability	GENERAL	The property of a claim that lets a reader who was not there reach the underlying data without asking you: named source, period, sample and definition.

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Sources

All links freely readable — no paywalled papers, no books you have to buy.

- 1. Project closure reporting standard for digital and ICT-enabled projects** — Australian Government Architecture / Digital Transformation Agency
The standard an Australian Government digital or ICT-enabled project closure report is actually assessed against. Seven criteria, each rated Strong, Emerging or Nil, self-assessed by the agency before the report is finalised. This is the spine of this course.
<https://architecture.digital.gov.au/standard/project-closure-reporting-standard-digital-and-ict-enabled-projects>
- 2. Digital project closure report templates** — Australian Government Architecture / Digital Transformation Agency
Templates built by the DTA with the ATO to meet the standard. One for Tier 1 and Tier 2 projects, one for Tier 3 and smaller work. Agencies may use their own template provided it meets the criteria.
<https://architecture.digital.gov.au/design/digital-project-closure-report-templates>
- 3. Guidance on the Assurance Reviews Process (RMG 106)** — Australian Government / Department of Finance
The operating guidance for Gateway. Defines the gates, including Gate 6 (Benefits Realisation), and what a Senior Responsible Officer is accountable for at each.
<https://www.finance.gov.au/publications/resource-management-guides/guidance-assurance-reviews-process-rmg-106>
- 4. Gateway Reviews Process** — Australian Government / Department of Finance
Scope and thresholds: \$30m for procurement or infrastructure, \$30m where the ICT component is at least \$10m, \$50m for programs. Applies to non-corporate Commonwealth entities.
<https://www.finance.gov.au/government/assurance-reviews-and-risk-assessment/gateway-reviews-process>
- 5. Gateway Review Process — Lessons Learned** — Australian Government / Department of Finance
Aggregated observations across Australian Government Gateway reviews. The closest thing the Commonwealth has to published reference-class data on why delivery goes wrong.
<https://www.finance.gov.au/publications/lessons-learned/gateway-review-first-edition>

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6. **Project closure — Financial Statements Better Practice Guide** — Australian Government / Department of Finance
The financial-side expectations at closure: costs finalised, assets recognised, obligations settled or transferred.
<https://www.finance.gov.au/government/financial-reporting-and-accounting-policy/financial-statements-better-practice-guide/12-project-closure>
7. **Annual performance statements for Commonwealth entities (RMG 134)** — Australian Government / Department of Finance
Where closure evidence ends up. Performance statements are audited, so a claim made at closure can be tested a year later.
<https://www.finance.gov.au/government/managing-commonwealth-resources/annual-performance-statements-commonwealth-entities-rmg-134>
8. **Reporting Meaningful Performance Information** — Australian National Audit Office
The auditor's view of what makes a performance claim meaningful rather than merely reported. Useful as the standard a closure report is written to survive.
<https://www.anao.gov.au/work/insights/reporting-meaningful-performance-information>
9. **Administration of the Gateway Review Process** — Australian National Audit Office
Performance audit of Gateway itself, including how consistently review recommendations are acted on after the review closes.
<https://www.anao.gov.au/work/performance-audit/administration-the-gateway-review-process>
10. **Archives Act 1983 and records authorities** — National Archives of Australia
Records authorities give permission to destroy, retain or transfer Commonwealth records and set minimum retention periods. Destruction without authority is unauthorised however it happens.
<https://www.naa.gov.au/information-management/records-authorities/types-records-authorities>
11. **Retaining, managing and disposing of data and datasets** — National Archives of Australia
Data held in business systems is a Commonwealth record. Access must be maintained for the prescribed period, and migration to a new system does not discharge the obligation.
<https://www.naa.gov.au/information-management/disposing-information/retaining-managing-and-disposing-data-and-datasets>
12. **Commonwealth Procurement Rules** — Australian Government /
[Skip to learning content](#) Contract sits inside. Relevant at closure for final acceptance, warranty and defects liability, retentions, and

obligations that survive termination.

<https://www.finance.gov.au/government/procurement/buying-australian-government/commonwealth-procurement-rules>

13. **Benefits management — Government Project Delivery (Teal Book)**

— UK Government / Infrastructure and Projects Authority

Comparator practice. Benefits management as a whole-of-lifecycle discipline owned by the business, not a closure-time activity owned by the project.

<https://projectdelivery.gov.uk/teal-book/home/part-e-planning-and-control/chapter-19-benefits-management/>

Closure Reports — unofficial internal learning aid. Built from Commonwealth assurance and performance frameworks. Content reviewed 16 August 2026. Not an official Australian Government publication.

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